

COMPLETED CASE PR/FAQ

Digikala Instant Exchange

A completed model answer for presentation, discussion, and deeper review.

Fictional case	Same SKU exchange	One visit promise	Limited pilot
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Decision recommendation: proceed to a limited discovery prototype and operational feasibility test; do not authorize broad launch yet.

CASE STATUS

Digikala Instant Exchange is an illustrative case study, not a real Digikala initiative. All personas, customer voice, targets, volumes, zones, and operational details are illustrative case assumptions.

READ FIRST

Status, customer, and pilot boundary

ILLUSTRATIVE CASE STUDY

This document is not a real Digikala announcement, plan, or policy. All personas, quotes, numbers, targets, zones, and operating details are illustrative case assumptions.

Target customer

A customer who received a defective or incorrect eligible item, still needs the product soon, and wants to avoid waiting through a return-refund-reorder cycle.

Customer problem

The customer has already spent time choosing and receiving the item. When it is wrong or defective, the current recovery path may add uncertainty, extra steps, and time without the product they intended to use.

Pilot boundary

- Eligible customers request an exchange in the app.
- Only Digikala-fulfilled, in-stock, non-heavy products are eligible.
- The replacement is the same SKU and is reserved before confirmation.
- Only selected return reasons and three selected Tehran delivery zones are in the pilot.
- A courier swaps the replacement for the original item in one visit.
- If the handoff cannot be completed, the customer keeps the standard return path without penalty.

Evidence status

The need, baseline, eligibility rate, operational capacity, economics, and risk thresholds require validation. The case uses assumptions to demonstrate how a PR/FAQ makes those unknowns visible.

PRESS RELEASE

Digikala pilots one-visit exchanges for eligible purchases

Eligible customers can request a same-SKU replacement in the app; Digikala reserves it and a courier swaps it for the original item in one scheduled visit.

TEHRAN - Illustrative future date - Digikala today announced a limited pilot of Instant Exchange, a new recovery experience for selected Digikala-fulfilled purchases in three selected Tehran delivery zones. When an eligible item arrives defective or incorrect, the customer can request an exchange in the app without first completing a return and placing a new order.

After eligibility is confirmed, Digikala reserves the same SKU and offers an exchange window. At the visit, the courier hands over the replacement and receives the original item. The app shows the request, reservation, appointment, and completion status. If the exchange cannot be completed, the customer keeps access to the standard return path without penalty.

The pilot is designed to test whether a tightly bounded one-visit experience can reduce customer effort while maintaining reservation integrity, quality, safety, and economic control. It does not change seller-fulfilled returns, refunds, different-SKU replacements, heavy-product handling, or general return policy.

ILLUSTRATIVE COMPOSITE CUSTOMER VOICE

'I still needed the product. Knowing the replacement was reserved and that one visit would handle the exchange removed the uncertainty.'

The team will first validate customer demand, prototype the end-to-end experience, test inventory and courier operations in shadow mode, and instrument the required metrics. A named sponsor will ratify any irreversible policy or investment decision before a live pilot.

EXPERIENCE

What the customer would experience

1. Open the order and choose 'Request exchange' for an eligible reason.
2. Review the eligibility result, same-SKU replacement, handoff conditions, and fallback path.
3. Confirm the request only after the replacement is reserved.
4. Choose an available exchange window and receive status updates.
5. At the visit, hand the original item to the courier and receive the replacement.
6. See completion in the app; if the visit fails, use the standard return path without penalty.

Customer FAQs

1. Who can use Instant Exchange?

During the illustrative pilot, selected customers with eligible Digikala-fulfilled, in-stock, non-heavy products, selected return reasons, and addresses in three selected Tehran delivery zones. Eligibility rules are an assumption to validate and must be explained before confirmation.

2. Can I choose a different color, size, or product?

No. The pilot is limited to the same SKU. A different product, color, or size follows the existing return and purchase path.

3. When is the replacement guaranteed?

The customer sees confirmation only after a replacement is reserved. The pilot must measure reservation loss and provide an immediate fallback if the reservation breaks.

4. Do I pay again?

The model assumes no new customer payment for an approved same-SKU exchange. Payment, deposit, and policy implications require sponsor ratification before any live pilot.

CUSTOMER FAQs

Recovery, privacy, and access

5. What if I cannot hand over the original item?

The exchange is not completed. The app explains the next step and preserves the standard return path. Repeated failed handoffs may affect future eligibility only under a separately ratified, transparent policy.

6. What if the courier cannot complete the visit?

The customer keeps the original item, the replacement returns to controlled inventory, and the customer can reschedule when operationally safe or use the standard return path. The failure reason must be visible to support and measurement systems.

7. What information does the courier see?

Only the information required to perform the handoff, such as address, contact instructions, exchange identifier, package/SKU check, and permitted failure reasons. The exact data view requires privacy and operational review.

8. Is the flow accessible?

It must support clear language, screen-reader navigation, sufficient contrast, non-color status cues, and a support-assisted path. Accessibility evidence is a release-confidence input owned by Design with QA involvement.

9. Can I still use the standard return path?

Yes. Instant Exchange is optional for eligible customers. Ineligibility or a failed swap must not remove the standard return option or create a penalty within the model case.

INTERNAL FAQs

Inventory, state, and architecture

1. How is replacement inventory reserved?

The feasibility hypothesis is a dedicated reservation state with expiry, source-of-truth ownership, and observable transitions for requested, reserved, scheduled, in transit, completed, failed, released, and returned. The Tech Lead owns the direction; engineers create option evidence.

2. What prevents confirmation without stock?

Customer confirmation occurs only after the inventory source of truth accepts the reservation. Timeout, duplicate request, cancellation, and stale-stock behavior must be tested. Reservation integrity is a pilot guardrail.

3. Which systems must agree?

At minimum: order/returns state, inventory reservation, delivery tasking, customer app status, support tooling, fraud/risk signals, and analytics events. The pilot should minimize new coupling and define reconciliation for inconsistent state.

4. What is reversible?

Eligibility thresholds, zones, invitation volume, scheduling windows, and pilot duration can be changed or stopped. Payment policy, customer penalties, seller obligations, and broad inventory architecture are treated as hard-to-reverse decisions requiring named sponsor ratification.

5. What is the smallest technical test?

Prototype the customer state model and run a shadow reservation against a controlled inventory set without promising a live exchange. Measure state consistency, expiry, and reconciliation before integrating courier execution.

INTERNAL FAQs

Logistics, handoff, and quality

6. How is the courier task different?

The task has two controlled assets: the replacement and the expected original. It needs clear package identifiers, handoff checks, failure codes, safe-carry rules, and custody transitions. Operations must validate route and capacity impact.

7. Does the courier diagnose defects?

No. The courier performs only the ratified handoff checks, not a technical defect assessment. Ambiguous or unsafe items follow the fallback path. Detailed inspection occurs through the appropriate quality/returns process.

8. What quality evidence is required?

QA owns a risk-based strategy covering eligibility, state transitions, reservation loss, duplicate/late events, cancellation, failed handoff, support recovery, accessibility, privacy exposure, and pilot stop controls. Release confidence is evidence, not a final testing phase.

9. What are the stop conditions?

Any serious safety incident attributable to the flow; material privacy or policy breach; uncontrolled reservation inconsistency; sustained failed-swap or support-contact guardrail breach; or inability to reconcile custody and customer status.

10. How are returned items handled?

The model assumes the original enters the existing controlled returns path with a distinct exchange identifier. Disposition, refurbishment, seller accounting, and defect classification remain outside the customer promise but must be operationally reconciled.

INTERNAL FAQs

Abuse, sellers, support, and accessibility

11. How do we manage misuse without harming legitimate customers?

Start with narrow eligibility and observable signals. Do not introduce opaque penalties in the pilot. Review false positives, explain ineligibility, preserve the standard return path, and require sponsor ratification for any customer-affecting policy.

12. Why exclude seller-fulfilled products?

The boundary avoids changing seller obligations, inventory custody, settlement, and pickup operations before the core customer and operational hypothesis is tested. Seller expansion is a separate PR/FAQ and policy decision.

13. What does support need?

A single view of eligibility, reservation, appointment, custody state, failure code, messages shown, and allowed recovery actions. Support contact rate and unresolved-case age are guardrails; overrides must be logged.

14. What accessibility evidence is required?

Design owns evidence that the request, eligibility explanation, schedule, status, and recovery flow work with assistive technology and plain language. QA verifies agreed acceptance criteria; support validates the assisted path.

15. Who owns customer communication during failure?

The Product Manager owns narrative coherence; Design owns interaction definition; operational message triggers require an implementation DRI. The customer must never be left with conflicting app, courier, and support states.

INTERNAL FAQs

Economics, measurement, and rollout

16. What economics matter?

Incremental courier handling, reverse-logistics load, reservation holding cost, replacement loss/damage, support load, engineering/operations cost, and any saved refund/reorder or churn cost. The case contains no factual economics; Finance/Operations validation is required before investment.

17. How will selection bias be handled?

Record eligible population, invited population, accepted requests, confirmed requests, completed swaps, failure reasons, and comparison cohort. Data owns definitions and validity; targets are not interpreted until baseline and denominator are agreed.

18. How do we roll out safely?

Research and prototype; shadow reservation; employee/internal simulation; tightly capped live pilot in three selected zones; expand only after a decision review. Each stage has a named DRI, entry evidence, guardrails, and stop authority.

19. Who decides whether to expand?

The Product Manager owns the outcome narrative and recommendation. QA owns release-confidence evidence, Data owns learning validity, TL owns technical feasibility, and EM owns delivery health. One named Product or Engineering Sponsor is the ratifying DRI for the investment decision.

20. What would make the team stop rather than iterate?

A hard stop condition, evidence that the customer problem is weak, inability to protect the standard return path, economics outside the agreed threshold, or an irreversible dependency disproportionate to the validated benefit.

PRODUCT FRAME

Tenets and non-goals

Tenets

- Promise only what is reserved and operationally observable.
- One visit should reduce customer effort, not transfer complexity to the customer or courier.
- Failure must preserve a clear, penalty-free standard return path.
- Evidence outranks confidence; assumptions are labeled and tested.
- Quality, accessibility, privacy, and safety shape the design from the start.
- Keep the pilot reversible until customer value and operating feasibility are demonstrated.

Non-goals

- Redesigning all returns or changing the general return policy.
- Supporting seller-fulfilled, heavy, out-of-stock, or different-SKU exchanges.
- Providing instant refunds, product upgrades, or open-ended substitutions.
- Making couriers diagnose product defects or resolve policy disputes.
- Launching nationally or committing to permanent architecture before staged evidence.
- Treating the completed case boundaries as binding organizational policy without leadership ratification.

EVIDENCE

Assumption ledger

Area	Illustrative assumption	Impact	Learning method	Owner
Customer need	Eligible customers value speed and certainty enough to choose a one-visit exchange.	High	Interview + concept test	Designer
Eligibility	The narrow boundary produces enough volume to learn.	High	Historical eligibility analysis	Data analyst
Reservation	Inventory can be reserved with fewer than 3% broken confirmations.	High	Shadow reservation test	Tech lead
Logistics	Courier routes can handle two-asset custody safely and reliably.	High	Controlled operations simulation	Engineering manager
Handoff	Customers can prepare the original item and complete the swap in one visit.	Medium	Usability + dry run	Designer / QA
Support	No more than 10% of requests require support contact.	Medium	Instrumented pilot	PM / Data
Misuse	Narrow rules control misuse without unfairly blocking legitimate customers.	High	Risk review + false-positive audit	Sponsor / Data
Economics	Incremental cost is justified by customer value and avoided recovery cost.	High	Pilot unit economics	Product sponsor

EVIDENCE RULE

An assumption becomes evidence only when the source, method, date, population, and limitations are recorded. A target is not a baseline.

MEASUREMENT

Illustrative success metrics and definitions

Metric	Illustrative target
Primary outcome	At least 80% of confirmed pilot exchanges complete within 48 hours.
Customer effort	At least 20% lower effort score than the measured standard-exchange baseline.
Reservation integrity	Fewer than 3% of confirmed requests lose the reserved replacement.
Failed swap	Fewer than 5% of courier visits fail for an avoidable process reason.
Support contact	No more than 10% of requests generate an exchange-related support contact.
Misuse signal	Fewer than 2% of requests are flagged for suspected misuse; review false positives.
Safety	Zero serious courier or customer safety incidents attributable to the pilot flow.

Definition notes

- Confirmed exchange: replacement reservation accepted and exchange window confirmed.
- Completed within 48 hours: completed timestamp minus confirmation timestamp is no more than 48 hours.
- Avoidable failed swap: failure caused by a process, communication, scheduling, state, or custody defect within pilot control.
- Support contact: any exchange-tagged inbound contact from request through seven days after resolution.
- Customer effort: a consistent post-resolution question measured for pilot and comparison populations.

ALL TARGETS ARE ILLUSTRATIVE

Data must confirm metric definitions, baselines, denominators, segments, and validity before the targets guide a real decision.

RISK

Risks, mitigations, and decision owners

Risk	Consequence	Mitigation / evidence	DRI
Broken reservation	Customer loses trust after confirmation.	Shadow test; reservation expiry and reconciliation.	Tech lead
Failed handoff	Extra effort and two disrupted assets.	Clear prep, failure codes, safe fallback.	EM / QA
State inconsistency	App, courier, and support give conflicting answers.	Source of truth; reconciliation; observability.	Tech lead
Misuse control	Fraud loss or unfair customer exclusion.	Narrow rules; false-positive review; no opaque penalty.	Sponsor
Accessibility gap	Customers cannot understand or complete the flow.	Research, acceptance criteria, assisted path.	Designer
Quality escape	Unsafe or incorrect exchange outcome.	Risk-based testing and stop authority.	QA
Courier safety/custody	Harm, loss, or unclear accountability.	Simulation, safe-carry rules, custody scan.	EM
Poor learning validity	Pilot result drives the wrong decision.	Population funnel, comparison, denominator audit.	Data analyst

EXPERIMENT

Staged plan and decision recommendation

Stage	Illustrative design	Exit evidence	DRI
1. Customer evidence	5-8 interviews plus concept test with eligible-like customers.	Problem, comprehension, value, recovery needs.	Designer
2. State prototype	Clickable flow plus support view and failure states.	Usability and accessibility evidence.	Designer / QA
3. Shadow reservation	Controlled SKU set; no customer promise.	Reservation integrity and reconciliation.	Tech lead
4. Operations simulation	Internal dry runs with courier/custody steps.	Safety, capacity, failure taxonomy.	EM / QA
5. Limited live pilot	Up to 500 invitations; three selected zones; 4 weeks or 300 completed eligible exchanges.	Outcome and guardrails.	PM
6. Decision review	Written evidence pack and sponsor decision.	Expand, iterate, pause, or stop.	Named sponsor

RECOMMENDATION

Proceed only to customer evidence, experience prototype, shadow reservation, and operations simulation. Authorize a capped live pilot only if entry evidence passes and one named sponsor ratifies the investment/policy decision.

Decision rule after a live pilot

- Expand if the primary outcome and customer-effort direction are met, guardrails remain within range, and no hard stop condition occurs.
- Iterate if customer value is evident but one or more reversible process guardrails miss.
- Pause if measurement validity, reservation integrity, or operational control is insufficient to interpret the result.
- Stop if the problem is weak, the fallback cannot be protected, economics are disproportionate, or a serious safety/privacy/policy condition occurs.

GOVERNANCE

Decision rights and open decisions

Decision	DRI	Required input
Target customer, problem, and outcome	Product manager	Designer, Data analyst, QA
Research plan and interaction definition	Designer	PM, QA, Engineers
PR/FAQ coherence and prioritization	Product manager	All role lenses
Technical direction and feasibility	Tech lead	Engineers, EM, QA
Capacity, sequencing, and delivery health	Engineering manager	TL, Engineers, PM
Implementation evidence for a scoped option	Named engineer	TL, QA, Data analyst
Test strategy and release confidence	QA	Designer, TL, Engineers
Metrics, baseline, instrumentation, learning	Data analyst	PM, QA, Engineers
Irreversible investment or policy decision	Named ratifying sponsor	Other sponsor plus relevant DRI

Open decisions before a live pilot

- Exact eligibility, geography, volume cap, and return reasons.
- Payment/deposit treatment and any customer-affecting policy.
- Inventory reservation source of truth and reconciliation design.
- Courier custody checks, safety rules, and failure taxonomy.
- Baseline, metric definitions, comparison design, and sample decision rule.
- Stop authority and the single ratifying sponsor for investment/policy decisions.

CONFLICT RECORD

For every unresolved decision, write the decision, evidence, DRI, reversibility, deadline, dissent/risk, and commitment after the decision.

REFERENCE

Sources and labels

- Colin Bryar and Bill Carr, Working Backwards, St. Martin's Press, 2021, for general method background.
- No current Digikala service or policy claim is relied upon. All case content is illustrative.